Girl in Pieces

By Kathleen Glasgow

CHARLIE: **(Pg 81-83)** A girl is born.

Her father loves her. Her mother loves her father.

Her father is sad.

Her father drinks and smokes, rocks and cries.

Into the river, he goes.

The mother becomes a fist.

The girl is alone.

No one likes the girl.

She tries.

But her mouth is mush

Stupid girl. Angry girl.

Girl finds knife. Girl makes herself small, small, smaller.

World gone.

Girl meets girl. Beautiful Girl! They watch planets move on the ceiling.

Beautiful Girl meets Wolf Boy. He fills her up, but makes her small.

Girl stays with Beautiful Girl, but wolf boy leaves drugs.

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Beautiful Parents are angry. Beautiful Girl lies and blames Girl for drugs.

Girl on street. Girl goes home.

Beautiful Girl texts and texts. Something wrong Hurts

Girl slips headphones on. Girl slides phone under pillow.

Beautiful Girl bleeds too much.

Girl gets messed up too, too messed up, broken heart, guilt.

World gone.

INTRODUCTION

Studies show that 75% of girls with low self-esteem reported engaging in negative activities like cutting, smoking, drinking and drugs. Charlie Davis is one of those girls. Nearly broken by a suicide attempt and a rush of personal losses, she finds solace in the broken shards of a mason jar.

First came the death of her father, followed by her mother's abuse and abandonment. Charlie turns to her only friend, Ellis, her Beautiful Girl. But Ellis is battling her own demons and is left stuck in limbo -- cutting deeply enough to cause significant blood loss but ***not*** *enough to die.*

Bandaged and silent, Charlie ends up in a psych unit for self-harmers, trying desperately to put herself back together. Girl in Pieces, by Kathleen Glasgow.

(Intro by 4N6 Fanatics Staff)

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CHARLIE: **(Pg 3)** Like a baby harp seal, I'm all white. My forearms are thickly bandaged, heavy as clubs. My thighs are wrapped tightly, too; white gauze peeks out from the shorts Nurse Ava pulled from the lost and found box behind the nurses' station. Like an orphan, I came here with no clothes. Like an orphan, I was wrapped in a bedsheet and left on the lawn of Regions Hospital in the freezing sleet and snow, blood seeping through the flowered sheet. The security guard who found me was bathed in menthol cigarettes and the flat stink of machine coffee. He said, "Holy Mother of God, girl, what's been done to you?" My mother didn't come to claim me. But I remember the stars that night. They were like salt against the sky, like someone spilled the shaker against very dark cloth. That mattered to me, their accidental beauty. The last thing I thought I might see before I died on the cold, wet grass. *(beat)*

(Pg 4) The girls here, they try to get me to talk. I hear their stories every day in Group, at lunch, in Crafts, at breakfast, at dinner. . .These words that spill from them, black memories, they can't stop. Their stories are eating them alive, turning them inside out. They cannot stop

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talking. I cut all my words out. My heart was too full of them.

(Pg 5) I room with Louisa. Louisa is older and her hair is like a red and gold noisy ocean down her back. There's so much of it, she can't even keep it in with braid or buns or scrunchies. Her hair smells like strawberries; she smells better than any girl I've ever known. My first night here, when she lifted her blouse to change for bed, I saw them, all of them, and I sucked my breath in hard. She said, "Don't be scared, little one." I wasn't scared. I just never seen a girl with skin like mine. *(beat)*

(Pg 9) Sometimes I can't breathe in this Goddamn place; my chest feels like sand. I don't understand what's happening. I was too cold and too long outside. I start to panic, shake, choke, and Louisa, she comes up very close to me in our room. She cups my cheek and even that makes me flinch. She says, "Little one, you're with your people." *(long Pause as Charlie is lost in thought)*

(Pg 15) We're never in darkness. Every room has lights on in the walls that ping on at 4 p.m. and ping off at six a.m.

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How long have I been here? I'm waking from something. From somewhere. A dark place.

(Pg 20) It isn't true that I want to be like the turtle and be alone. What's true is that I want Ellis back, but she can never come back, ever, ever. Not the way she was, anyway. When I think about Ellis, I feel sadness, and while I say sadness, what I really mean is a black hole inside me filled with nails and rocks and broken glass and the words I don't have anymore. *(beat)*

(Pg 42) The first time I ever cut myself, the best part was after: swabbing the wound with a cotton ball, carefully drying it, inspecting it, this way and that, cradling my arm protectively against my stomach. ***There, there.***

I cut because I can't deal. It's as simple as that. The world becomes an ocean, the ocean washes over me, the sound of the waves is deafening, the water drowns my heart, my panic becomes as large as planets. I need release, I need to hurt myself more than the world can hurt me, and then I can comfort myself. ***There, there.***

(Pg 44) It hurts to make a river. The pain is sharp and bleary all at once; curtains part and shut over your eyes; bull

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breath from your nostrils. It f**** hurts, hurts, hurts. But when the blood comes, everything is warmer and calmer.

(Pg 90) I wondered why [Ellis] picked me to be her friend: me with my haphazardly cut red-and-black hair, my holey cardigans and ripped jeans.

(Pg 69) I know who I am. I mean, I don't *know* know, because I'm only 17, but I know who I am when I'm with people, or when they're looking at me. [I'm] that one, the kid who never gets anything right, and sits alone in the cafeteria, and draws all the time, and sometimes she gets mad and punches, because what else is there? So when [someone] says, "Who keeps your secrets?" I think, "Nobody." Nobody until Ellis.

(Pg 74) [Sometimes] I say Ellis killed herself, but she did not die, die. She isn't in the ground. There were drugs, wolf boy, and she slid very far from me. And when the wolf was done, he left her gaunt, my Ellis, my plump and glowing friend. And then I guess she tried to be like me. She tried to drain herself, make herself smaller, only cutting wasn't her thing. I imagine her room soaked in

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blood, rivers of it, her parents fighting upstream to get to her. But there was too much, do you understand? A person can only lose so much blood, you can only starve the brain of oxygen for so long, or you suffer an anoxic brain injury after hemorrhagic shock, which emptied out my friend and left only her body.

(Pg 342) The text messages flicker in front of my eyes.

Smthing hrts. U never sd hurt like this. 2 much.

(Pg 40 – 41) The hands on the wall clock tell me it's time to get my bandages off. It's one of the day nurses, Vinnie, who does it, his big hands chapped and methodical. He pauses before he begins unpeeling the pads on my arms. "You want someone here?" I shake my head, No. "Yeah, that's right. You a tough girl, Davis."

(Pg 41-42) Carefully he unwinds the gauze from each arm. They make a wet soft, thwack as he tosses them in the metal trash bin. I stare at the ceiling lights so hard dark clouds form over my eyes. There's the sound of trickling water. Vinnie is washing his hands. I lift my arms up. They're pale and puckered from being wrapped up for so long. Turning them over, I look at the red ropy scars

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rivering from my wrists to my elbows. I touch them gingerly; there, there. Underneath these new scars, I can see the old ones. My scars are like a dam or something.

(Pg 45-46) My eyes are fierce with water, and I want Ellis, the Ellis who would dab my cuts and steal wine from her dad so we could cry together. Because when you're hurt, and someone loves you, they're supposed to help you, right? When you're hurt and someone loves you, they kiss you tenderly, and they hold the bottle to your mouth, they stroke your hair with their fingers, right? I'm in a place filled with girls who are filled with longing and I want none of them. I want the one I can't have, the one who is never coming back.

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AWARD HISTORY

NIETOC
IA State Qualifier
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